



■ By Prabhu Chawla

Ma...Maya...Mayawati. This is one incantation that, in its audibility and audacity, rises above the usual din of desperation in Indian politics today. Believers blinded by her halo—or by the flash of her diamond rings?—are convinced that her day has come and only she can remove the curse of bipolarity that keeps the dispossessed away from the highest seat of power. She, at her imperious and benevolent best, plays the role of Our Lady of Deliverance to perfection, all set to take that revolutionary leap from Kalidas Marg in Lucknow to Race Course Road in Delhi. As her spell spreads, guess who're falling at her feet with total submission. Among the growing legion of salvation seekers are chieftains from regional satrapies, newly disarmed Stalinists who still blame it all on proofing errors in the Book, and sundry freelancers from the fringe—all characters in search of a winning plot and a director. She knows that the final victory will be a subversion of the established hierarchy of power. So her destination is history itself.

That is why when the prime minister won the trust vote on the nuclear deal, Mayawati refused to see it as a long-term political setback. In that moment of adversity, she saw an opportunity. Overnight, the chief minister of India's most influential state became the third pillar of Indian politics—Sonia Gandhi and L.K. Advani being the other two. Courtesy the nuclear deal, the non-Congress, non-BJP political alignment got a mascot, and mind you,

